# Parshas Pinchas

*Emotional Alignment and the Courage of Bitul*

*Pinchas · Bnos Tzelafchad · Bitul · Bruc HaShalom*

## I. The Misconception About Pinchas

One of the greatest misconceptions about Parshas Pinchas is that it is a story about zealotry. At first glance that reading seems obvious. Pinchas takes dramatic action in response to a public desecration of Hashem's Name and the Torah confirms that his act stopped a devastating plague. Yet if the parsha were truly about zealotry, the reward it describes seems unusual.

Hashem does not reward Pinchas with honor, power, or prestige. What Hashem gives him is this:

וְהִנְנִי נֹתֵן לוֹ אֶת בְּרִיתִי שָׁלוֹם

*"Behold, I give him My covenant of peace."*
*— Bamidbar 25:12*

Why peace? Because Pinchas was never acting from fanaticism. He was acting from alignment. And the reward reflects the nature of the act.

## II. The Background: What Bilam Could Not Do

To understand who Pinchas was, it helps to recall what brought things to this point. At the end of last week's parsha, Bilam, after multiple failed attempts to curse Klal Yisrael, steps back and uses his spiritual awareness differently. He tells Balak that there is another way to attack a nation that Hashem has already blessed and cannot be cursed directly. The vulnerability is from within. Draw them into immorality and avodah zarah, and they will bring destruction upon themselves.

Balak followed the advice. The women of Moav enticed the men of Klal Yisrael into immoral behavior and idol worship. A plague erupted among the people. And in the midst

of this crisis, one of the leaders of the tribes acted publicly and brazenly, openly endorsing the behavior as if daring anyone to challenge him.

Into that moment stepped Pinchas. But before understanding what he did, it is worth understanding who he was.

## III. Who Pinchas Was

Pinchas ben Elazar was the son of a Kohen, the grandson of Aharon HaKohen. Yet because of the timing of his birth, before the formal consecration of the Kehunah, he did not carry the status of Kohen himself. He was a Levi. There was room, humanly speaking, to feel that the system had passed him over. His father and his family carried a sacred role that he himself was excluded from through no fault of his own.

Many people in that position challenge the system. They resent the structure, push against the hierarchy, or use their grievance to justify behavior that steps outside its boundaries. Pinchas did none of that. He was not part of Korach's rebellion. He was not involved in attempts to overturn the existing order. In many ways, Pinchas had a more legitimate claim than Korach ever did, being of actual priestly lineage, yet Pinchas was able to say: this is my reality, and I am at peace with it. What he was not at peace with was watching people destroy themselves and bring catastrophe upon Klal Yisrael.

## IV. He Went to Moshe First

Pinchas knew the halacha. He understood what the Torah required in a situation of this kind. He knew that a plague was spreading. He felt the weight of what was happening with his entire being. And yet, rather than act immediately on that feeling, he went to Moshe Rabbeinu.

This is the part of the story that is most often overlooked. Pinchas was not a fanatic acting on impulse. He understood something that many people never learn: strong feelings do not automatically make us right. His emotions were real and his read of the situation was accurate, but he recognized that the very intensity of what he felt could cloud his judgment. So he turned to his teacher. He submitted his understanding to Torah. He asked, in effect: Moshe, I believe this is the correct din, but I do not want to pasken from within my own outrage. What does the Torah require?

Moshe confirmed that his understanding was correct. The din was as Pinchas understood it, and Pinchas was the right person to act. Only then did he act. Not from uncontrolled passion. From alignment.

## V. Emotional Health Is Not the Absence of Emotion

This distinction is one of the central themes of Sefer Bamidbar, which we have returned to again and again. Emotional health is not the absence of emotion. It is the ability to experience powerful emotions without allowing them to become the ultimate authority. The goal is never to become numb or detached. The goal is to feel fully and still remain in alignment with Hashem's ratzon.

Pinchas felt deeply. He was not indifferent to what was happening around him. But he refused to let his feelings replace Torah. That refusal is itself a form of kedushah. The Alter Rebbe in Tanya speaks about the challenge of the beinoni, the person who experiences every pull of the lower self yet does not act on it. The greatness is not in not feeling. The greatness is in the space between feeling and acting, a space that Pinchas used wisely, walking it straight to his rebbi's door.

## VI. The Daughters of Tzelafchad

The same lesson appears in the parsha through an entirely different story, told with entirely different emotional texture. The daughters of Tzelafchad find themselves in a painful position. Their father has died leaving no sons, and according to the existing laws of inheritance they face losing their family's portion in Eretz Yisrael.

Who was Tzelafchad? The mefarshim offer two primary identifications. One opinion holds that he was among those who went up toward Eretz Yisrael after the decree following the sin of the meraglim, despite being told that the nation would not succeed in that attempt. Another opinion identifies him as the mekoshesh eitzim, the one who publicly violated Shabbos so that Klal Yisrael would understand the severity of the commandment. Whatever the correct identification, the common thread is someone who cared deeply about Hashem's will, even when he did not always arrive at the right conclusion in how to express that care.

His daughters inherited that orientation toward truth. They could have responded to their situation with resentment, framed themselves as victims, or attacked a system that seemed to leave them behind. They did none of that. They approached Moshe with humility and clarity. They asked a question. They trusted the process. They submitted their pain and their claim to the Torah's framework rather than demanding that the framework conform to them.

When the ruling came in their favor, they accepted not only the privilege but also the responsibility that accompanied it, agreeing to marry within their shevet so that the inheritance would remain where it belonged. Privilege and responsibility understood as inseparable. That is bitul in action.

## VII. Alignment Precedes Elevation

The outcomes of these two stories carry a quiet message worth sitting with. Pinchas, who accepted his reality without bitterness and acted only in alignment with Hashem's will, was elevated into the Kehunah, receiving the very status he had never claimed for himself. The daughters of Tzelafchad, who approached with humility and bitul, became the vehicle through which a new halacha was revealed to all of Klal Yisrael.

The mefarshim explain that Moshe either forgot this halacha or had not been taught it specifically so that the daughters of Tzelafchad would receive the merit of bringing it forward. The revelation was waiting for the right vessel. It found those vessels precisely because they came without ego, without demand, and without the conviction that the world owed them an answer before they had even asked the question.

Both stories teach the same thing. Alignment precedes elevation. The gift comes after the bitul, not before.

## VIII. What This Asks of Us

The world tells us constantly to trust our feelings above all else, that what we feel is who we are and that any system asking us to examine or contain those feelings is a threat to our authenticity. The Torah teaches something more nuanced and, ultimately, more demanding. Feelings matter. They are real. They contain information. But they are not

always truth, and they are not always a reliable guide to what Hashem wants from us in a given moment.

The challenge of a Torah life is learning to recognize our emotions, honor them, bring them to a rebbi or a teacher rather than act on them alone, and then move from a place of alignment rather than impulse. That was the greatness of Pinchas. That was the greatness of the daughters of Tzelafchad. And it is a challenge that does not belong only to dramatic moments. It belongs to ordinary life, to the frustration in a relationship, to the grievance that feels entirely justified, to the strong conviction that we know exactly what needs to happen.

The question worth carrying into Shabbos is not whether the feeling is real. It almost certainly is. The question is what we do next. Do we act from it, or do we bring it to Torah first?

**חזק ואחזק**

*Good Shabbos*

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## Reflection Questions

- *Is there a feeling or conviction I am currently holding that I have not yet brought to a teacher, a rav, or a trusted framework? What is the step between feeling it and acting on it?*
- *Like Pinchas, is there a place in my life where I feel I have been passed over or excluded from something I deserved? Am I at peace with that reality, or is it quietly shaping how I behave?*
- *The daughters of Tzelafchad accepted both the privilege and the responsibility of their ruling. Where in my life am I seeking the privilege without fully accepting the responsibility that comes with it?*
- *When did I last bring a strong emotional reaction to Torah before acting on it? What happened as a result, and what would have happened if I had acted first?*
- *What is the difference between emotional health and emotional detachment? Where in my avodah do I need more feeling, and where do I need more structure around what I feel?*
- *Alignment precedes elevation in both stories in this parsha. Where in my own life do I sense that I am waiting for the elevation before I am willing to do the alignment?*